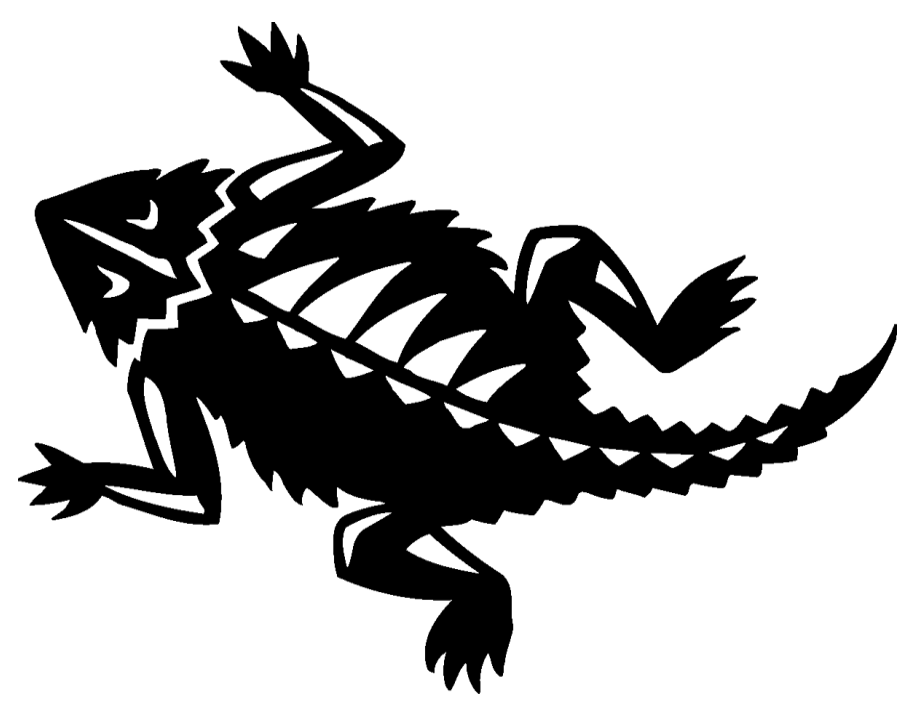
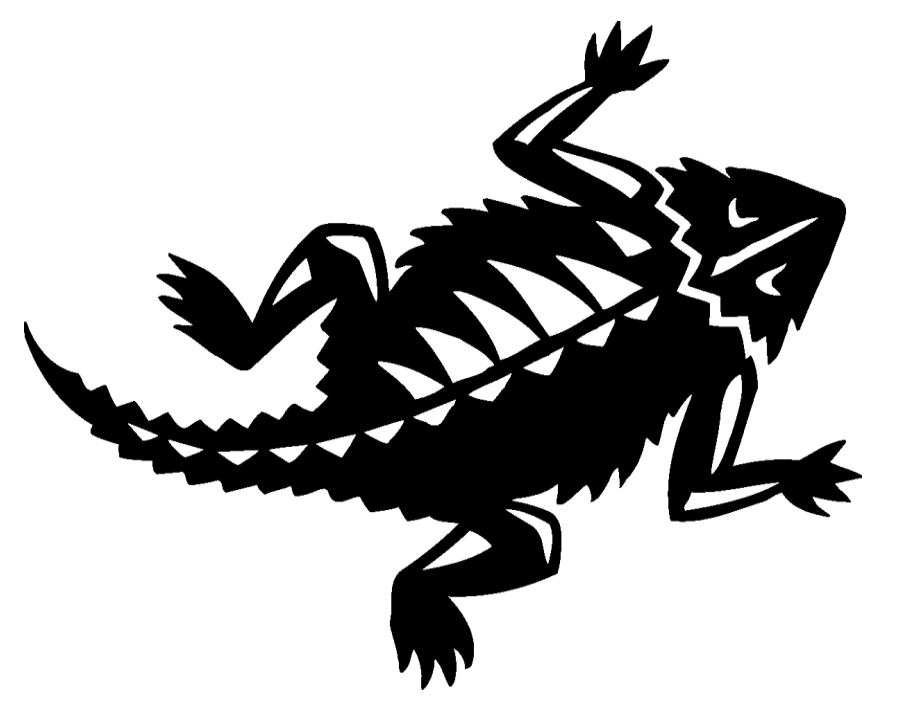




Cartography in Colonial México: Pintura de Culhuacán

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Introduction

In 1577, Philip II of Spain sent out a series of questionnaires called the *Relaciones Geográficas* to the furthest reaches of his overseas empire, requesting answers to 50 questions along with maps. Pedro de San Agustín, an indigenous man, painted the *Pintura de Culhuacán* in 1580 to accompany the *Relación de Culhuacán*. Indigenous communities actively participated in the questionnaire, but indigenous painters like San Agustín were less common.

The maps produced by indigenous painters were syncretic products that reflected the presence and influence of both Europeans and Indigenous people in the Americas. This project examines the role of cartography during the conquest period and how indigenous cartographic traditions provided communities another way to preserve their self-image and culture.

Materials and Methods

Materials: Identified materials in Texas Archival Resources Online (TARO), and later conducted archival research at the Nettie Lee Benson Latin American Collection at UT Austin.

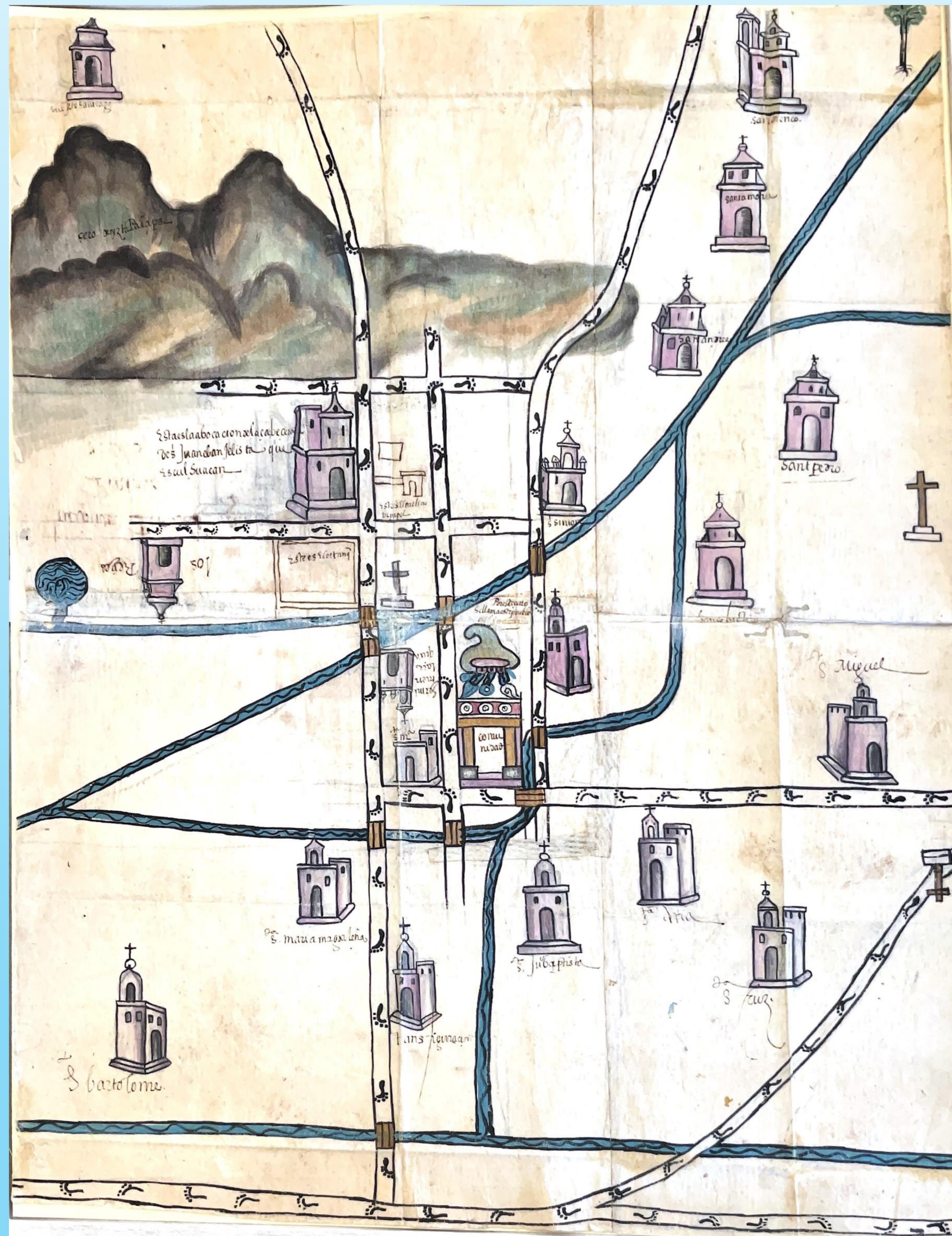
Visual Analysis: Divided painting's elements into human features, including buildings and roads, and natural features, represented by waterways and the physical environment.

Categorizing by Artistic Style: Explored secondary source literature on the history of Indigenous and Spanish mapping to learn who influenced each element.

Historical Context: Examined histories of the Valley of Mexico pre- and post-contact, referencing the questionnaire responses in the *Relación de Culhuacán*.

Themes

- Indigenous Identity and Permanence: Enduring presence and resilience of indigenous culture
- Human-Environment Interactions: Reciprocal relationship between humans and their environments
- Regional Culture and Economy: Local economic and cultural practices
- European Influence: Impacts of colonization on culture and society



Results

European Influence & Audience:

Pedro de San Agustín painted the map for the court of King Philip II of Spain.

- Map labels are in alphabetic writing with European place names (figures 1 & 2)
- Churches are depicted in a 3D European style (figure 1), appealing to the European audience expectations
- Churches representing towns dominated the landscape to show the success of the evangelization project (Mundy)



Figure 2. "Comunidad."

Indigenous Presence:

Indigenous cartographers included symbols of their own history and culture.

- Comunidad* building depicted with indigenous architecture and marked by the Nahuatl glyph of *Coloa* (figure 2), representing Culhuacan (Mundy)
- Footprint motif common in indigenous cartography (figures 1, 2, & 3)

Implicit Economic Narrative:

Inclusion of land and water features highlights primary pre- and post-conquest economic activities in the central valley.

- The hill at Iztapalapa, a key stone quarry (figure 4)
- Canals facilitated transport of stone and other good across the lake and between cities in the region (figure 3)

Figure 3. Canal feeding northward to Lake Texcoco.



Figure 4. "Cero de Yztapalapa."



Citations

- San Agustín, Pedro de. "Pintura de Culhuacan." 1580. JGI XXIII-14. Joaquin García Icazbalceta Manuscript Collection. Nettie Lee Benson Latin American Collection. The University of Texas Library, Austin.
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Results

Built Environment:

This map was made to show human uses of space.

- It showcases 19 parochial communities, 2 secular buildings, and 3 burial grounds (figure 1)
- Extensive road networks, bridges, and canals (figures 1 & 2), indicates a dense population and human activity (Mundy)

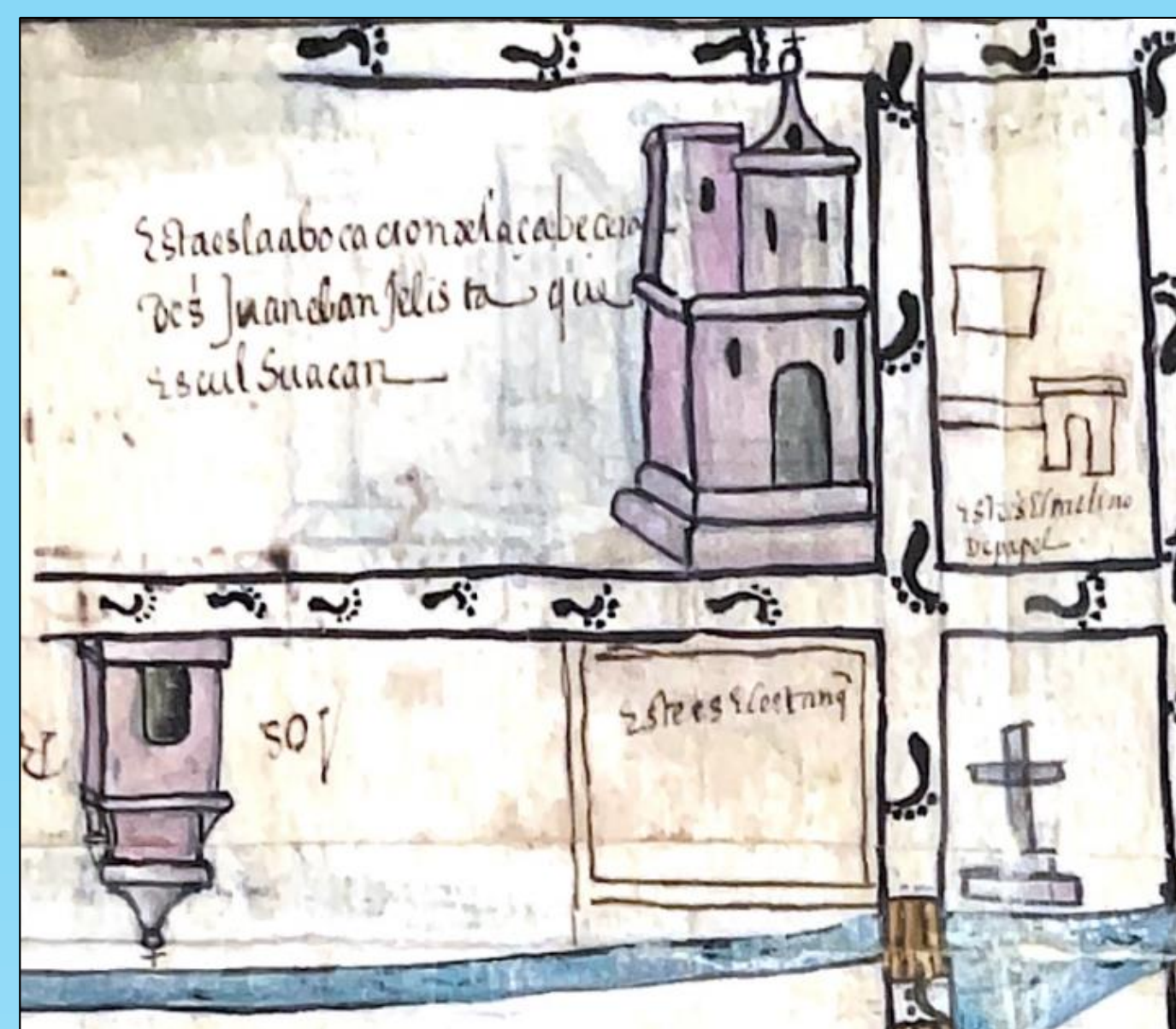


Figure 1. *Pintura de Culhuacán*, detail. Augustinian Monastery.

Conclusions

Indigenous Cartographic Practices: The inclusion of indigenous imagery, such as Nahuatl glyphs, traditional depictions of footprints, and representations of Indigenous architecture in cartography were used by Indigenous people to create a more permanent record of their communities while making concessions to serve the desires of outside communities, such as the Spanish.

Environmental Narratives: San Agustín evoked a narrative of indigenous interactions with the environment to reference the extensive economic and political network of cities in the Valley of Mexico, which were centered on the waterways of Lake Texcoco. These records came at a time when projects to divert the waters of Lake Texcoco were first being considered, projects that would significantly change the region's physical geography and how humans, especially indigenous people, interacted with their environment.

Furthering Scholarship: These advances can help build scholarship on the relationship between indigenous communities and the environment, as well as Indigenous and Spanish relations in this period of the 16th century that is post-conquest but prior to the drainage of Lake Texcoco.